

Area of Study 3A - Catholic Christianity

Overview

This area of study comprises a study in depth of aspects of Philosophy and Ethics in the context of Catholic Christianity as a lived religion within the United Kingdom and throughout the world.

There are two sections: Arguments for the Existence of God; Religious Teachings on Relationships and Families in the 21st Century.

The significance and importance of the various beliefs, issues and practices to Catholics today should be explored throughout the two sections. This should include reference to how the Bible informs a Christian's understanding of the topics and how approaches to the issues are underpinned by philosophical arguments and ethical theory as applicable.

Students will be expected to study Catholic Christianity within the context of the wider British society, the religious traditions of which are, in the main, Christian. Students should recognise that Catholic Christianity is one of the many religions and world views in Great Britain, which include Buddhism, Hinduism, Islam, Judaism, Sikhism and non-religious views such as Humanism and atheism. This knowledge may be applied throughout the assessment of the specified content.

Students should compare and contrast the areas of ethics and/or philosophy within Catholic Christianity with wider Christian perspectives and non-religious views as outlined in the content below.

Students should also recognise that within Catholic Christianity there may be more than one perspective in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed. Common and divergent views within the wider Christian tradition in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed should be included throughout, including reference to Orthodox, Protestant and other Christian traditions.

Students should have an understanding of:

1.1	Revelation as proof of the existence of God: the significance of Jesus Christ as the culmination of God's revelation; what the revelation of Jesus Christ shows about the nature of God for Catholics, including reference to Hebrews 1:1–4.
1.2	Visions as proof of the existence of God: the nature and importance of visions for Catholics; biblical and non-biblical examples of visions, including Joan of Arc and Genesis 15 and Matthew 17:1–13; reasons why they might lead to belief in God, and Catholic responses to non-religious arguments (including atheist and Humanist) which maintain that visions are hallucinations and provide no proof that God exists.
1.3	Miracles as proof of the existence of God: the nature and importance of miracles for Catholics; biblical and non-biblical examples of miracles, including those at Lourdes and John 4:43–54; reasons why they might lead to belief in God and Catholic responses to non-religious arguments (including atheist and Humanist) which maintain that miracles can be scientifically explained and provide no proof that God exists.
1.4	Catholic attitudes towards religious experiences and its use as a philosophical argument for the existence of God: the nature of religious experience and why not all religious experiences are approved by the Church, including reference to Catechism of the Catholic Church 66–67; Catholic responses to non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) arguments that religious experiences do not provide proof that God exists.
1.5	Design argument: the classical design argument for the existence of God and its use by Catholics as a philosophical argument for the existence of God; understandings of what the design argument shows about the nature of God for Catholics, including Romans 1:18–24; Catholic responses to non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) arguments against the design argument as evidence for the existence of God.
1.6	Cosmological argument: the cosmological argument for the existence of God and its use by Catholics as a philosophical argument for the existence of God, including reference to Thomas Aquinas' First Three Ways of showing God's existence; understandings of the nature and importance of what the cosmological argument shows about the nature of God for Catholics; Catholic responses to non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) arguments against the cosmological argument as evidence for the existence of God.
1.7	Issues raised by the existence of suffering and God as all-loving: the issues it raises for Catholics about the nature of God, including Isaiah 45; how the problem and its basis as a philosophical argument may lead some to examine and others to reject their belief in God.
1.8	The solutions offered to the problem of suffering and a loving and righteous God within Catholicism: biblical, theoretical and practical responses – Psalms, including reference to Psalm 119, Job, free will (St Augustine), as a way for humans to develop (St Irenaeus), prayer, and charity; divergent understandings within Christianity of their success in solving the problem.